minus symbol becomes a plus sign. The living rise up, the lifeless lie prone on the ground. This division sign is a symbol of separation and of distribution, which are inevitable results of an increase in number," she quotes.

Haloi's work does not court abstraction for the sake of obscuring meaning unlike artists like Wassily Kandinsky (with whom Haloi is often compared), feels art historian and faculty member of Kala Bhavana, Santiniketan, Soumik Nandy Majumdar. The "abstract in his work exists more as a tendency" and a "linguistic strategy and not as an aim", he says in his essay 'Painter of the Twilight Zone'. This is why Haloi is unwilling to "attach the term abstract to his works".

This linguistic strategy that Nandy Majumdar mentions is delineated the most in Haloi's children's books illustrations, some of which also appear in the book. It is a sheer delight to read *Cholte Cholte*, a 2001 children's book that shows the brother-sister duo of Pintu and Parul returning from their village school, and observing these very symbols make up Haloi's artistic language amidst nature. *Frogs and a Snake*, a 1995 children's book brought out by the National Book Trust, is a vivid vignette of nature.

When asked about the book, Haloi himself felt most understood by Polish curator and author Adam Szymczyk, curator at large of Stedelijk Museum Amsterdam, whose essay 'The Song, Not the Words' seemed to have particularly moved him. Szymczyk explores the artist's biography to decode his work and finds parallels between Haloi's childhood village with its "unclear borders between habitation and arable land, marshes divided by canal" and the way he paints, "the difference between abstraction and concrete detail being only matter of an always shifting distance".

Abstract or concrete, pensive or joyful, silent or strident—the book makes it clear that all these definitions are a matter of "shifting distance". ■

Malini Banerjee

ART

A TALE OF TWO GALLERIES

Art House and **Gallery XXL** are welcome—and very different—additions to the art spaces of Mumbai

Art is art, right? But two new art galleries in Mumbai showcase the sheer range of artistic perspective, with two very different approaches to art.

One, ensconced in the glamorous Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre at the Bandra-Kurla Complex, is a plush four floors of hues. This contemporary space, designed to use sunlight to best effect, has been dubbed the Art House. It opened with a group show titled *Sangam/Confluence*, a collaboration of curation by American art expert Jeffrey Deitch and Indian cultural theorist Ranjit Hoskote, featuring over 50 artworks and installations by five international and five Indian artists, among them Anselm Kiefer and Bhupen Khakhar. The show mixes moods and media to tell the tale of India's rich and diverse culture. Quotes from the artists on the walls accompany you as you move up the floors, while the audio guide with Hoskote's narration adds nuanced perspective. This is art, polished to perfection and presented on a platter.

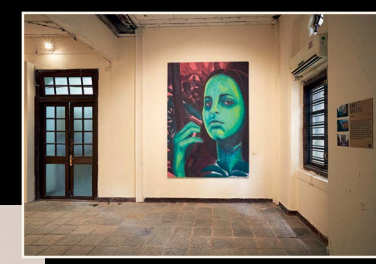
GALLERY XXL represents contemporary urban and post-graffiti art sincerely, but with a wink and a chuckle

Quite the contrast is Gallery XXL, which represents contemporary urban and post-graffiti art sincerely, but with a wink and a chuckle. The founders—Giulia Ambrogi, Hanif Kureshi, Arjun Bahl, Thanish Thomas and Akshat Nauriyal—who were also behind the St+Art India Foundation that has become well known for urban art across India, believe that Gallery XXL is the logical extension of that vision, of taking art out of stuffy drawing rooms and making it accessible. This is not a static space, but one that exists in the minds of its curators first and then manifests physically in various locations.

XXL's first show, *Outsiders*, is housed in The Kalanjee Project, a gorgeous 19th-century home in a Colaba by-lane. Curated by artist Amitabh Kumar, it offers a peek into the global street art movement: from iconic photographs by stalwart Martha Cooper, who documented the emergence of the movement in 1970s New York, to AIKO's bunnies, to Indian street artists Daku and Guesswho, whose work is seen everywhere while their identities remain concealed. It sets the context of how the 24 participating artists fit into the global timeline spanning almost 50 years.

Gallery director Joe Cyril tells us how the intention was to find a space that would reflect the type of collections they had in mind. Gallery XXL aims to be 'an intimate space to engage with an art form that has otherwise been enjoyed from afar'. The unique interiors of the Kalanjee bungalow, at once raw and refined, seem like the perfect foil for this. At both galleries, boundaries—geographical and psychological—are being broken. And that's always a good thing when it comes to art. ■

Priya Pathiyan





DIFFERENT PERSPECTIVES
(left) *Sangam/Confluence* at the Art House, Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre; (top) *Outsiders* at Gallery XXL, The Kalanjee Project